

Session 31: The Sabbath With No End

Key Takeaways

- The seventh day is the only day of creation that has no end. This tells us that God's ideal is for his glorious presence to dwell among humanity forever.
- Jesus sees himself as inaugurating God's ultimate Sabbath rest and the super Jubilee year (Isa. 61:1-2).

The Jubilee Year of Release and Restoration: Leviticus 25

Leviticus 25:1-12 NASB

¹ The LORD then spoke to Moses at Mount Sinai, saying, ² "Speak to the sons of Israel and say to them, 'When you come into the land which I shall give you, **then the land shall have a sabbath** to the LORD. ³ **Six years** you shall sow your field, and six years you shall prune your vineyard and gather in its crop, ⁴ but during **the seventh year the land shall have a sabbath rest**, a sabbath to the LORD; you shall not sow your field nor prune your vineyard. ⁵ Your harvest's aftergrowth you shall not reap, and your grapes of untrimmed vines you shall not gather; the land shall have a sabbatical year. ⁶ All of you shall have the sabbath products of the land for food; yourself, and your male and female slaves, and your hired man and your foreign resident, those who live as aliens with you. ⁷ Even your cattle and the animals that are in your land shall have all its crops to eat. ⁸ You are also to **count off seven sabbaths of years for yourself, seven times seven years**, so that you have the time of the **seven sabbaths of years, namely, forty-nine years**. ⁹ You shall then sound a ram's horn abroad on the tenth day of the seventh month; **on the day of atonement** you shall sound a horn all through your land. ¹⁰ You shall thus **consecrate the fiftieth year** and proclaim a **release** through the land to all its inhabitants. It shall be a **jubilee** for you, and each of you shall return to his own property, and each of you shall return to his family. ¹¹ You shall have the fiftieth year as a jubilee; you shall not sow, nor reap its aftergrowth, nor gather in from its untrimmed vines. ¹² For it is a jubilee; it shall be holy to you. You shall eat its crops out of the field.'"

Key Takeaways from Leviticus 25

- Every seventh year is a Sabbath ("release" from Exod. 21; Deut. 15) in which the land rests and reverts to Eden conditions.
- Every 49th to 50th year is a Super Sabbath (release/Jubilee) where (1) the land rests on its proper Sabbath, (2) the land "goes out" from slavery to return to its original owners, and (3) slaves "go out" from slavery to return to freedom.
- The counting scheme works so that the 50th year is the first year of the next cycle.
- God will re-create Eden conditions if Israel obeys the Jubilee.

43	44	45	46	47	48	49 – Sabbath
50/1 – Jubilee	2	3	4	5	6	7 – Sabbath
8	9	10	11	12	13	14 – Sabbath
15	16	17	18	19	20	21 – Sabbath
22	23	24	25	26	27	28 – Sabbath
29	30	31	32	33	34	35 – Sabbath
36	37	38	39	40	41	42 – Sabbath
43	44	45	46	47	48	49 – Sabbath
50/1 – Jubilee	2	3	4	5	6	7 – Sabbath

Bergsma, John (2007). *The Jubilee from Leviticus to Qumran: A History of Interpretation*. Brill. 89.

Jubilee Anticipates a Future Restoration

“There is something inherently 'eschatological' about the jubilee, long before it was seen as a symbol of the eschaton by later writers. Since it recurred usually only once in a lifetime, the impoverished Israelite—or at least the one projected by the text—would spend most of his life in anticipation of this event of restoration. Also, from the perspective of the entire Pentateuch, the conquest and settlement of Canaan was a kind of “realized eschatology”—the fulfillment of the promise of the land of Canaan originally made to Abraham. Leviticus 25—in its present position in the Pentateuch—looks forward to the time when the 'eschatological' condition of Israel dwelling within her own land will be realized, and enacts measures to ensure that periodically this utopian, 'eschatological' state of Israel will be renewed and restored.”

Bergsma, John (2007). *The Jubilee from Leviticus to Qumran: A History of Interpretation*. Brill. 81.

The Jubilee in Luke’s Gospel

Luke 4:14-21 NASB

¹⁴ And Jesus returned to Galilee in the power of the Spirit, and news about him spread through all the surrounding districts. ¹⁵ And he began teaching in their synagogues and was praised by all. ¹⁶ And he came to Nazareth, where he had been brought up; and as was his custom, he entered the synagogue **on the Sabbath**, and stood up to read. ¹⁷ And the book of the prophet Isaiah was handed to him. And he opened the book and found the place where it was written,

¹⁸ The Spirit of the Lord is upon me,
because he anointed me to preach the gospel to the poor.
He has sent me to proclaim **release** to the captives,
and recovery of sight to the blind,
to **set free** those who are oppressed,
¹⁹ to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor.

²⁰ And he closed the book, gave it back to the attendant and sat down; and the eyes of all in the synagogue were fixed on him. ²¹ And he began to say to them, "Today this Scripture has been fulfilled in your hearing."

Isaiah 61:1-2 Instructor's Translation

¹ The Spirit of the Lord is upon me,
because he has anointed me
to bring good news to the poor;
he has sent me to **bind up the brokenhearted**,
to proclaim liberty to captives
and recovery of sight for the blind
² to proclaim the favorable year of the LORD

And the day of vengeance of our God ...

"Freedom" means "release" in Greek (*aphesis*) and "Jubilee liberation" (Isa. 61:1; Lev. 25:10) in Hebrew (*deror*). Freedom is the common word for forgiveness in Luke (1:77, 3:3), but the word's meaning is broader—release from burden or bondage. In Isaiah 61, the word is rooted in the year of Jubilee (Lev. 25) and is about release from the social consequences of a society's collective sin—freedom from debt, slavery, poverty, and oppression.

"The poor" (Grk. *ptokhos* = Heb. *aniy*) refers to more than a person's economic status. It refers to a person's wider social location based on family heritage, land ownership, vocation, gender, ethnicity, education, and religious purity. In Jewish literature, it refers to anyone of low status or anyone who lives outside socially accepted boundary lines.

"Jesus' mission is directed to the poor ... in the holistic sense of those who are for any number of reasons relegated to positions outside the boundaries of God's people. Jesus refuses to recognize those socially determined boundaries, asserting instead that these 'outsiders' now can belong to God's family."

Green, Joel (1997). [The Gospel of Luke](#). Eerdmans. 211.

"Jesus' claim to 'fulfill' Isaiah 61 must be seen as a claim to inaugurate the climactic Jubilee of God's people, the time when their freedom from captivity and oppression would be permanent. The main feature of Jesus' fulfillment of the Jubilee in Luke 4 is the proclamation of $\alpha\phi\epsilon\sigma\iota\varsigma$, which in Luke/Acts refers ... to forgiven sin and ... to release from physical/economic oppression."

Bruno, Christopher R. (2010). ["Jesus Is Our Jubilee ... But How? The OT Background and Lukan Fulfillment of the Ethics of Jubilee."](#) *Journal of Evangelical Theological Society (JETS)*. 98-99.

The Nazareth announcement in Luke 4 sets the agenda for Jesus' healing and teaching ministry in Luke 5-9 where he reaches out to:

- A leper ([Luke 5:12-16](#))
- A paralyzed man ([Luke 5:17-27](#)) [Note the use of *aphesis* to mean "forgiveness" of sin and "release" from sickness with multiple nuances in this story]
- A man with a deformed hand ([Luke 6:6-11](#)) [Jesus "saves life" on the Sabbath]
- The Roman centurion's servant ([Luke 7:1-10](#))
- The grieving widow and mother in Nain ([Luke 7:11-16](#)) ["God has come to visit his people"]
- The blind, leprous, lame, deaf, and poor ([Luke 7:22](#))
- A repentant prostitute ([Luke 7:36-49](#)) [Note the repetition of *aphesis* "forgiveness" and "release" in the parable]
- The demon-tormented ([Luke 11:14-23](#))
- The hunchbacked woman ([Luke 13:10-17](#)) [Note the explicit mention of slavery/release/freedom vocabulary in Jesus' view of her illness]

Reflection Question

When Jesus stands up and reads in the synagogue, he reads from Isaiah 61:1-2, saying that he is inaugurating the year of Jubilee. What significance does this have? What is Jesus saying he is inaugurating?